In short, the very idea of Bharat, its civilisational unity, its relationship with time and its subjectivity have been tied to the advent of the coloniser, independent of whom it is assumed that Bharat had no consciousness of its own. This is glaring evidence of an abysmal understanding of the global history and nature of colonialism.

The clearest proof, of course, is the fact that the ‘independent’ Indian State tests its standing on the global stage not on its ability to reclaim its consciousness and live by its own values, but on the basis of its position in the ‘global order’ (read the West) as a ‘civilised nation’. There does not appear to be a conscious attempt on the part of the Indian State to break free from the universalised fictions and illusions created by coloniality. Therefore, a decolonial approach to rid Bharat of coloniality is imperative.

This is not possible without challenging the predominance of postcolonialism in Bharat given its role in perpetuating coloniality. To this end, it is important to understand the specific manifestations of coloniality in Bharat, especially the following, which have altered its consciousness in the most fundamental of ways:

1. The impact of the Christian European coloniser’s conceptions of ‘religion’ on Indic OET systems and the attendant alienation of nature;
2. The application of the coloniser’s racial lens to Bharat’s societal structures, which gave rise to what we understand today as ‘caste’ and ‘tribe’;
3. The introduction of the coloniser’s education system at the expense of indigenous knowledge production and education systems;
4. The imposition of the Westphalian nation-state model on a diverse civilisational society; and
5. The impact of the coloniser’s notion of ‘development’.

Surprisingly, each of these is abundantly supported by the literature except that the underlying cause, namely coloniality, which is common, has not been paid attention to.

Before I am misunderstood and labelled a revisionist, let me clarify that I do not mean that prior to the advent of the European coloniser there were no stratifications or hierarchies in Bharatiya society. However, it is certainly my case, based on the literature on coloniality and its impact on societal structures of other colonised societies, that the manner in which religion, caste and tribe are understood in contemporary Bharat bears a distinct